



CLASS OF '90
FASHION DESIGN



STYLE SETTERS: (From left) Sonam Dubal, Ritu Beri, Narendra Kumar Ahmed from the first batch

NATIONAL INSTITUTES OF FASHION TECHNOLOGY CUTTING EDGE

Fashion wasn't an industry 18 years ago. I didn't know what it stood for. I hadn't heard of anyone who had taken up fashion designing as a full-time career. The concept of ritualistic dressing was predominant. And Chandni Chowk was an unrivalled destination.

I'd decided to pursue my graduation in medicine after school. But it was in 1986 that the government opened a fashion designing school, and I thought, this is something different. How difficult could the entrance be? I decided to give it a try. What I thought would be a cakewalk, turned out to be the most intensive entrance examination, followed by an interview. I was surprised that I got through.

The Union Ministry of Textiles had taken up the shopping complex area at Samrat Hotel, New Delhi, to set up the institution. We used to have our classes there, until it was shifted to the Indira Gandhi Stadium. It was like an Indianised-version of the Fashion Institute of Technology (FIT), New York. Everything from the faculty, curriculum to the tools, was imported from FIT. Not for a second did I ever regret my decision to choose fashion over medicine.

The National Institute of Fashion Technology (NIFT) is a class apart. Just as fashion is dynamic—changing every season in terms of colour, prints, material, and preference, NIFT maintains its pace with this rapid-fire

industry, by training faculty, upgrading courses and adopting state-of-the-art technology. The international industry was the only developed model for us to follow in the 1980s. Back then we gave fashion any form, colour, size or print we fancied. People were not trend setters. They wanted whatever they saw on others. Today, dressing is a way of life, a portrayal of the self, an identity—where everyone competes to be different. It was very difficult to convince people that fashion was a serious business then. But with the expertise of the faculty and thorough understanding of the industry at NIFT, I earned my first export order from Liberty, London in 1990. It was the garment I designed for my final term.

What began with a class of 25 fashion design students in 1986 has gone up to 30 for each of the seven undergraduate design programmes at NIFT today. But hard work has remained a constant. From the first day in college we learned that fashion wasn't glamour. Establishing an individual name was challenging. Although, opportunities and demand for trained manpower is greater in the industry today, the generation-Y fashion aspirants have a trickier path ahead, as both the Indian and international markets have matured.

by Ritu Beri

The author is a NIFT alumnus

18,580

students applied for various courses across eight centres of NIFT in 2007, of which 1,650 were finally selected.

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The number of new NIFT centres coming up in Kannur, Shillong, Bhopal and Patna.

RS 87 CRORE

The annual budget of eight NIFT centres for the year 2008. It was Rs 70 crore last year.